

EXAMINED

Picostone Basic and Polar

Since its initial popularity, the approach to home automation has gone under a transformation. While hefty, all inclusive solutions for your entire home are still being implemented, we've also seen a rise in the number of plug-and-play solutions from several established and new brands. Picostone falls in the second category with its smart switch offerings Basic and Polar.

The Basic is essentially a black box that goes behind your switchboard. It requires a sizeable switchboard to be installed behind without cutting or damaging existing wires. With a maximum capacity of controlling four switches, the Picostone Basic should be enough for any standard living room. If connected to a regulator, the Picostone Basic also allows you to control the fan speed or light intensity (for dimmable lights). The electrical installation is pretty basic and while an official electrician is available from the Housejoy team, you can do it yourself too if you're inclined towards DIYs.



Picostone Basic



Picostone Polar

Once all the wires are in place you'll need to use the Picostone app and follow the instructions to connect your phone to the switches. The initial setup uses a device WiFi to configure your home WiFi onto the Basic, but post that it connects via your home WiFi network. The

interface is quite simple and allows you to control a variety of things like room configurations, individual switch configuration and more. These switches are also IFTTT compatible, so you can pull up some fun applets and try them out as well.

Polar is a dedicated product from Picostone for air conditioner. Polar along with IR Stone use a proprietary IR communication method to keep your AC controls on your phone. The installation is pretty simple, even simpler than the Basic. All you need to do is plug the Polar into a suitable plug point, and then place the IR Stone at a place where it can generate an IR signal to reach your AC. Then, connect to the Picostone network generated by the Polar and configure the Polar and the IR stone. Once that is done, you can pick your AC remote from their list or add your own. This easy to configure approach makes Picostone's switches a good choice for basic home automation.

PRICE: BASIC: ₹11,799/-; POLAR WITH IR STONE: ₹3,999/-

Boggle Slam

Boggle is a popular word building game, which is a little cumbersome to play. You have to jumble up multiple dice, get a pen and paper, and race against other friends with a sand clock. After all this, you have to sit and calculate the points that you scored. The smart-phone version, available on the app stores are fun too, if you enjoy the gameplay. Boggle Slam is a card version of the game that is much more simpler, and much more fast paced.

The gameplay is pretty straightforward. You start off with a four letter word on the table and distribute the remaining cards among all the players. The game says 2-4 players, but we have comfortably played with up to seven players using the same amount of cards. Each card has a letter on the front and the back. Some

of the cards are blank, which are placeholders or "joker" cards that can be used in the place of any letter. Then the fun begins, everyone has to get rid of all the cards on their hands by changing a single letter of the face up cards that you start with. This is not a turn by turn thing, but instead just how fast you are, and how quickly you can think on your feet. When a game goes well, it is incredibly fun for everyone involved. However, the game does not always go so well.



The oversimplification means that the core Boggle mechanic of finding words using a string of adjacent blocks is done away with. The game should not even be called Boggle anymore. The gameplay can be interrupted multiple times by obscure words known by only one person, or people willing to take an educated guess. A simple way to handle this is to ask the player to tell the definition of the word, before looking it up on Google, or a dictionary. The four card penalty should be applied if the person cannot define the word, irrespective of whether or not the word actually exists. This is a rule that emerged during gameplay to make it faster during our play-testing, and not in the actual rulebook. Another issue is that towards the end of the game, an impasse can be reached where no one can modify the four letters on the table into a legitimate word. Also, the game does get pretty boring after a few rounds, and typically the team tends to move on to Codenames or Psych!

PRICE: ₹125/-